



Arabic, Greek, and Spanish, as well as Italian influences. The soil of Sicily's coastal regions and the Mediterranean climate lend themselves to farming, and the region is famous for its grapes and citrus fruits.

Fishing is also extremely important to the local economy, though overfishing is a problem. The Mafia still operates in Sicily, but organized crime is no worse here than in some other parts of Europe.

Every day is a festa

Sicilians love their festivals and many are held in the course of a year. As well as Christian holidays such as Christmas and Easter, many people celebrate St. Joseph's Day in March, which commemorates the time when the saint saved people from famine. Every town and village holds celebrations to honor the local patron saint.

VILLAGE LIFE

Life on Sicily and the tiny islands associated with it runs at a peaceful pace. Shops open early and shut late, but they close for a rest during the hottest part of the afternoons, from 1 to 4 o'clock.

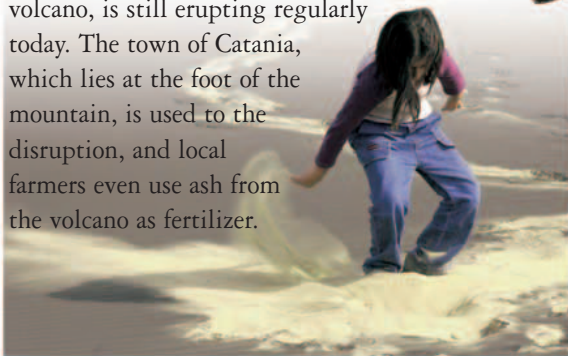


DEVIL MASKS

San Fratello hosts a Parade of Devils during the Good Friday Festival just before Easter. The parade began life as a religious ritual, but bright costumes and large crowds have given it the air of a carnival.

LIVING NEAR A VOLCANO

Mount Etna, Europe's most active volcano, is still erupting regularly today. The town of Catania, which lies at the foot of the mountain, is used to the disruption, and local farmers even use ash from the volcano as fertilizer.



PALERMO'S SAINT

The festival of St. Rosalia is the occasion for a spectacular parade every July in Palermo. Rosalia was born in Palermo and became a hermit. Nearly 450 years after her death, the discovery of her remains was said to have halted a plague devastating the city.

